Ethan O'Leary

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Education

2022–2026	**PhD in Economics,** Norwegian School of Economics (NHH) Supervisor: Erik Ø. Sørensen
2025	**Visiting Doctoral Researcher,** WZB & Humboldt University Berlin Hosts: Dorothea Kübler and Sebastian Schweighofer-Kodritsch
2019–2022	**MSc in Economics,** Stockholm School of Economics
2015–2019	**BSc in Economics,** University of Newcastle-upon-Tyne Exchange: McGill University

References

Prof. Erik Øiolf Sørensen, Norwegian School of Economics,
erik.sorensen@nhh.no

Prof. Sebastian Schweighofer-Kodritsch, Universität Leipzig,
sebastian.schweighofer-kodritsch@uni-leipzig.de

Prof. Bertil Tungodden, Norwegian School of Economics,
bertil.tungodden@nhh.no

Teaching and Research Fields

Behavioural Economics; Microeconomic Theory; Applied Microeconomics.

Job Market Paper

(Mis)anticipated Discrimination [Paper Access]
Award: Best Paper Award, The Young Economists' Meeting 2026

I propose and test a novel mechanism through which discrimination persists: the misperception of statistical discrimination as taste-based discrimination. I first derive a model of self-confirming discrimination in a job-application setting, in which misperceiving statistical discrimination as taste-based is a key channel: correctly attributed statistical discrimination admits both discriminatory and non-discriminatory equilibria, so inequality reflects a coordination failure, while misattribution to taste-based origins yields only discriminatory equilibria and lowers the perceived return to re-coordination. In a pre-registered laboratory experiment, subjects who experience discrimination from an ambiguous origin overestimate the probability that this inequality is caused by taste-based discriminators. This misattribution is associated with a higher probability that application strategies sustain statistical discrimination: a 1 percentage point increase in believed probability that discrimination is taste-based corresponds to a 0.35 (0.24) percentage point decrease (increase) in the probability that a subject in the discriminated (favoured) group applies to a job, perpetuating statistical discrimination. Moreover, the more likely subjects perceive the employer to be a taste-based discriminator, the more unfair they perceive the labour market and the lower their demand for a temporary affirmative action policy aimed at re-coordinating toward a less discriminatory outcome. This demonstrates that the persistence of discrimination is not only driven by the underlying source, but also the perception of such.

Working Papers

The Cultural Trust Gap: Discrimination Across England's North-South Divide [Paper Access]

Trust, the belief in another individual or organisation's intent to act in good faith, is a cornerstone of social prosperity. However, cultural norms significantly influence trust levels within and between groups, often leading to discriminatory behaviours that undermine cooperation. This paper investigates the impact of culture on trust using a novel experimental approach that isolates trust from confounding factors such as risk preferences and distributional concerns. The setting of the experiment is England, a culturally and economically divided nation. Focusing on self-identified Southerners and Northerners, I find evidence of a cultural trust gap. Specifically, while Southerners exhibit equal trust towards both groups, Northerners trust Southerners significantly less than their own group. By decomposing trust into its conditional and unconditional components, I show that this disparity is driven by unconditional trust: Northerners perceive Southerners as more selfish than their own culture.

Works in Progress

Expecting Bias: How Beliefs of Discrimination Shape the Gender Application Gap
With Roberto Caputo, Michael Hilweg-Waldeck, and Anita Zednik

The Fairness of Discrimination
With Erik Ø. Sørensen and Sebastian Schweighofer-Kodritsch

Revisiting Trust in Unequal Societies: Experimental Evidence
With Roberto Caputo

The Archaeology of Discrimination
With Ashley McCrea

Teaching

Undergraduate

Autumn 2026	Economics and Psychology (Lecturer; NHH)
2020–2021	Microeconomics 1 (TA; Stockholm School of Economics))

Graduate

Spring 2026	Behavioral Economics (Lecturer and TA; NHH)
2023–2026	Behavioral Economics (TA; NHH)
Autumn 2024	Behavioral Business Strategy (TA; NHH)
Autumn 2022	Introduction to the Global Economy (Lecturer; Stockholm School of Economics)

Grants

2026	German Association for Experimental Economics Research — EUR 2,000 *With Roberto Caputo, Michael Hilweg-Waldeck, and Anita Zednik*
	ZEW Research funds — EUR 3,800 *With Roberto Caputo, Michael Hilweg-Waldeck, and Anita Zednik*
2025	Norwegian School of Economics Centre for Ethics Grant — NOK 30,000 *With Roberto Caputo*
	Norwegian School of Economics Centre for Ethics Grant — NOK 30,000
	University of Mannheim Economics Department — EUR 50,000 *With Roberto Caputo, Michael Hilweg-Waldeck, and Anita Zednik*
	Professor Wilhelm Keilhaus Minnefond — NOK 50,000

	Norges Banks Fond til Økonomisk Forskning — NOK 20,000
2024	Norwegian School of Economics Centre for Ethics Grant — NOK 20,000

Conferences and Workshops

Upcoming	Copenhagen Network of Experimental Economists, Lund; 2027 ASSA Meeting (Session from Association for the Society of Generosity), Washington, DC.
2026	Young Economists Meeting, Brno; 3rd Annual Workshop on Behavioural Economics, Sheffield; FUR Conference, Alicante; The Chicago School in Experimental Economics, Osaka; 2nd Berlin Micro Theory & Behavioural Economics Conference, Berlin; EEA 2026, Dublin; 6th Discrimination and Diversity Workshop, online; NYU Abu Dhabi Behavioral and Experimental Economics Job Market Workshop.
2025	Newcastle University Experimental Economics Meeting, Newcastle-upon-Tyne; Max Planck / FAIR NHH Workshop, Bonn; Berlin Micro Theory and Behavioral Economics PhD Conference, Berlin; Society for Advancement of Behavioral Economics (SABE), Trento; Berlin-Bergen Behavioral Workshop, Berlin; Thurgau Experimental Economics Meeting, Kreuzlingen.
2024	Copenhagen Network of Experimental Economists, Lund; FAIR Spring School, UC San Diego.

Invited Talks

2025	University of Mannheim

Service

Referee: Journal of Political Economy Microeconomics

Organiser: Co-founder of STEAM 2027 (Special Topics for Early-Career Applied Microeconomists); Behavioural Economics Reading Group at NHH

Other Experience

2022	**Quantify Research,** Stockholm, Sweden Research Analyst in Real World Evidence (Health Economics)
2021–2022	**Stockholm Institute for Transition Economics (SITE),** Stockholm, Sweden Research Assistant to Prof. Jesper Roine

Additional Information

Software: Stata, R, Python, oTree, JavaScript, HTML

Languages: English (native), French (advanced), Swedish (intermediate), Spanish (beginner)

Last updated: November 10, 2026